Does qualifying decide an F1 race?

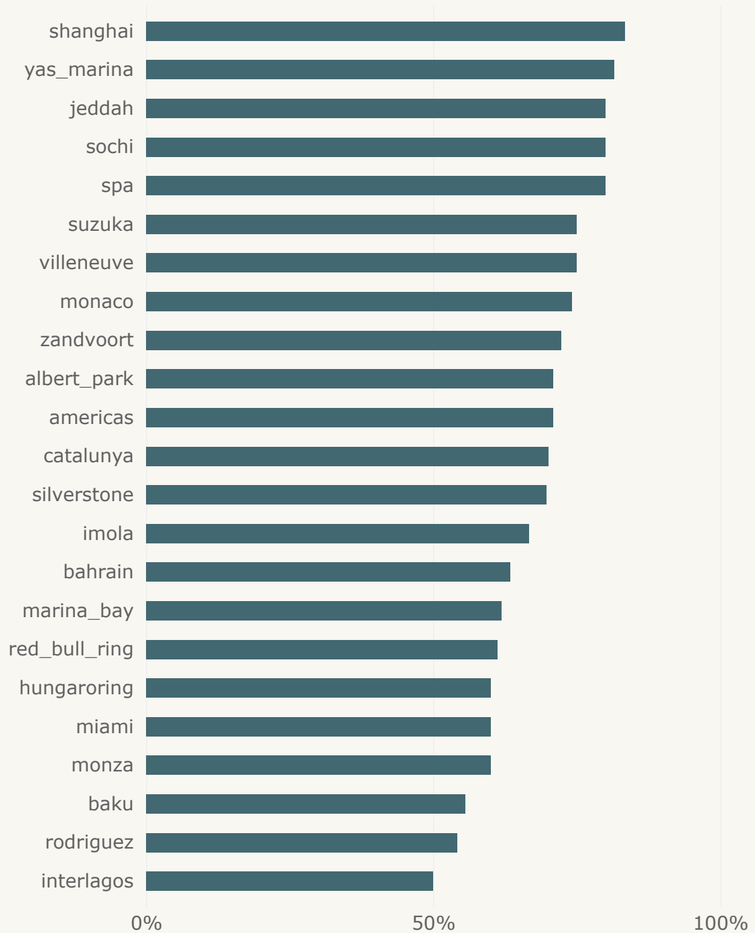
Top-3 qualifiers reach the podium 67% of the time, from 50% at Interlagos to 83% at Shanghai. My model matches that rule, with no proven edge.

Races analysed
209

Top 3 quali podium rate
67.3%

Pole win rate
55.0%

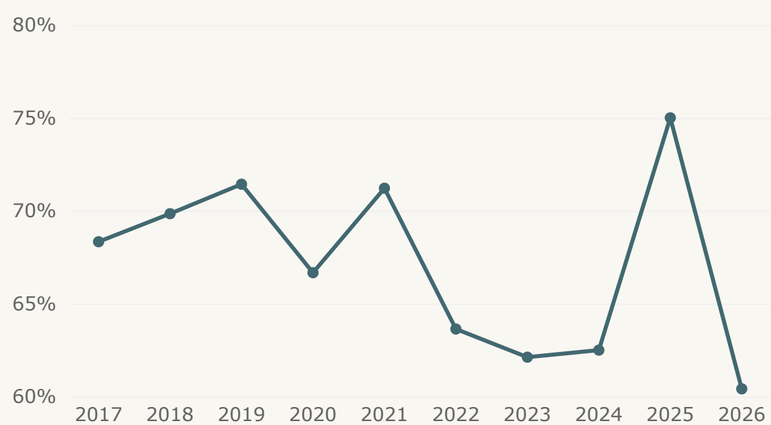
Where qualifying decides the race (top-3 qualifiers who reach the podium)



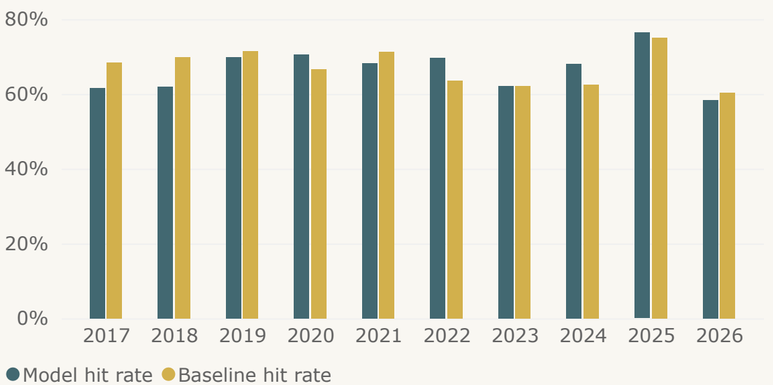
The further back you start, the further back you finish

Average start vs finish position by team

Top-3 qualifiers' podium rate by year



Model vs qualifying baseline: podium picks right, by year



Lower position = better. Teams are grouped across renames: Sauber includes Alfa Romeo and Kick Sauber, RB includes Toro Rosso and AlphaTauri; Audi (2026) is shown separately. Circuit chart shows circuits with 5+ races. Data: F1 results 2017-2026 (Jolpica-F1, OpenF1)